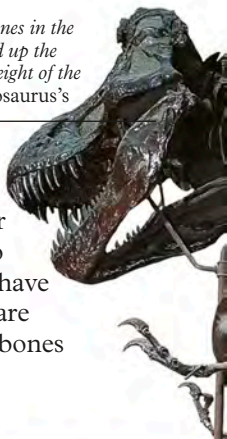




REBUILDING A DINOSAUR

Thick bones in the neck held up the heavy weight of the Tyrannosaurus's head.



Jigsaw puzzles can be tricky, especially if some pieces are missing and pieces from different puzzles are mixed in. People who rebuild dinosaur skeletons are faced with a similar puzzle. Fossil bones must be put together in the right order to form a skeleton. Bones belonging to different dinosaurs may have found their way into the collection by mistake. Missing bones are modeled by looking at the bones of similar dinosaurs. Broken bones must be cleaned and repaired before they can be assembled.

Back at the lab

Dinosaur bones are taken from the fossil site to a laboratory. Experts clean and repair them before they are rebuilt into a skeleton. Sometimes, fossils may be prepared for study, but are never displayed in museums.



1. First, the hard, protective plaster must be removed from the bone with special tools.

2. Next, the bones must be carefully cleaned. This stage can take a very long time.



3. The bones are then treated with resin to make them stronger. They must also be repaired, if necessary.



4. Finally, copies are made of the bones using a light material, like fiberglass. The copies, called casts, can be put together to make a museum display.

